

Is India Really That Bad, or Are We Trapped in an Information Cocoon?

Zhihu

One-sentence answer: India really is that bad, and we really are living in an information cocoon about India woven by self-media.

Let me expand on this below.

First, the Question of India's Badness

In this world of comparing badness, there are various kinds of bad.

In the preface to *Capital*, Marx, evaluating Germany, said: "In all other respects, we — like all other continental countries of Western Europe — suffer not only from the development of capitalist production, but also from the incompleteness of that development. Alongside modern evils, a whole series of inherited evils oppress us, arising from the passive survival of archaic and outmoded modes of production, with their accompanying train of anachronistic social and political relations. We suffer not only from the living, but from the dead. *Le mort saisit le vif!* — the dead grip the living!"

Today's China stands to India as the England of Marx's day stood to Germany. The "layoff at 35" phenomenon, middle-aged anxiety, express-station bosses bullying couriers, enterprises telling employees that entering the factory premises means abandoning all freedom, property prices soaring and crashing to harvest the middle class, the fear of having children, the "thirteen consecutive suicides at Foxconn" a decade and more ago, and the white-collar deaths from overwork that still occur from time to time — all these are modern evils.

India's evils are horrifying because its calamities include not only the modern evils we know well, but also pre-modern calamities inherited from antiquity.

Take sexual violence against women: it exists in every country, but in India it is truly serious — serious enough to trigger mass protests.

The rape and murder of a female doctor in India sets off an outcry over women's safety

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By Ruchi Kumar



Medical professionals and students take part in a protest rally after the rape and murder of a doctor in Kolkata on August 21. India's Supreme Court on August 20 ordered a national task force to examine how to bolster security for health workers.

Dibyangshu Sarkar/AFP via Getty Images

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Source: <https://www.npr.org/sections/goats-and-soda/2024/08/26/g-s1-18366/rape-murder-doctor-india-sexual-violence-protests>

Then there are husbands who "sell" or "rent out" their wives to pay debts. In China this would count as a bizarre tale, but news of this kind from India has been reported continuously since the mid-2000s.

Source: <https://www.deccanherald.com/india/madhya-pradesh/mp-woman-raped-after-husband-sells-her-to-friend-to-pay-off-debt-3600354>

Beyond the hyper-intensity of gender oppression, another pre-modern calamity of India is the caste system. Although every Indian I know tells me nobody cares about caste, it still suffuses Indian society. It is no longer the case, as before, that the caste into which you are born decides what work you can do — capitalist society naturally cannot coexist with a caste system that obstructs labour mobility. But the survivals of caste based on discrimination against the weak are still everywhere.

For instance, two low-caste Dalits in India were beaten to death for defecating in a public area.

And recently, a truly heart-breaking event in India: a young man and woman fell in love across castes, the boy was beaten to death in an "honour killing," and the girl finally chose to marry the boy's corpse. The report says the girl, against her family's pressure, married into her dead boyfriend's household. This counts as a contemporary young Indian woman's resolute revolt against the outdated, backward caste system — moving to tears:

Aanchal vowed to remain in Tate's house permanently, saying she would "live as his wife for the rest of my life." She alleged that Tate was murdered because of his caste and demanded a death penalty for all accused family members.

Link: <https://gulfnews.com/world/asia/india/our-love-won-woman-marries-boyfriends-body-after-honour-killing-in-maharashtras-nanded-1.500364754>

The entanglement of contemporary Indian youth with tradition, and their revolt, deserve attention.

Of course, India's badness also includes open defecation, slums, and the whole gamut of pre-modern problems of people not having enough to eat.

By comparison, the modern "badness" in India seems less prominent — but in truth these are the problems with which we resonate more.

For example, a textile worker, unpaid by his boss, chose suicide in the end.

The report says: "Kuldeep filed a complaint with the police, stating that her husband was frustrated with the factory owners' behavior. A few days ago, he had demanded his pending wages, but they again refused to pay. Feeling helpless, on January 25, he died by suicide." This shows that India, like many countries with weak labour protection, is a place where such labour disputes — report to the police, appeal to the labour department — are all useless, and people die in despair.

For example, property prices are rising fast, and young Indians cannot afford houses in the cities:

Source: <https://www.businesstoday.in/magazine/money-today/story/missing-homes-heres-why-owning-a-home-in-india-has-become-so-difficult-430821-2024-06-11>

Not only are sale prices high; rents are climbing steeply too. China once had a famous TV drama called Dwelling Narrowness and a book about white-collar renters in the city called Ant Tribe, both

about the difficulty of renting and buying housing in China. India now has its ant tribe as well — only in the age of self-media, no reporters are needed; the masses report their own suffering themselves.

For example: Indian university graduates also have difficulty finding jobs — the same as China, or even worse. Because India's high-end industries are not developed enough while university graduates are already numerous (about 10 million a year), a great many cannot find work.

Because jobs are hard to come by, competition in India's civil-service exams is also fierce. The Economist's report put the Chinese and Indian civil-service examinations side by side, both ranked the most brutal.

Workplace bullying in India is also severe, with suicides from time to time. This one from this year — the AI engineer who killed himself was a graduate of a prestigious school:

Source: <https://www.ndtv.com/india-news/25-year-old-krutrim-techie-found-dead-in-bengaluru-toxic-work-culture-blamed-8447681>

Then there is the case of a techie fired for asking for a 10% raise — does that feeling seem familiar?

Source: <https://www.indiatoday.in/education-today/news/story/techie-fired-after-asking-for-10-raise-6-hired-to-replace-him-bosses-sacked-2786662-2025-09-13>

Pre-modern calamities piled on top of modern calamities — how could such a society not be rotten?

Now the Question of the Information Cocoon About India

Misconception 1 about India: India's industry is very poor, at the level of the Nationalist government before liberation.

The productive forces are the foundation; one must first get clear about India's actual state of industrial and technological development.

Under my other related answers, I have introduced some of India's industries and parts of its high-tech manufacturing.

"Is India Seriously Underestimated in China?" — answer by 最最遥远的路 on Zhihu: <https://www.zhihu.com/question/349933016/answer/1979511765931942324>

On the whole, India's level of development trails China by about 20 years. India also has human resources as abundant as China's, and its university graduate numbers are already close to China's; in one or two decades it will have plenty of momentum for high-end manufacturing and services.

Misconception 2 about India: the development of Indian capitalism cannot break through pre-modern obstacles such as the caste system. India must first eradicate feudal survivals before it can

develop.

Lenin, in *The Development of Capitalism in Russia*, commenting on the Russia of his day, wrote: "If Russian capitalism had no room to expand beyond the territory it occupied in the post-Reform period, then this contradiction between large-scale capitalist industry and the archaic institutions of rural life (the peasants' being tied to the land, etc.) would inevitably lead to the complete abolition of these institutions, and to the complete clearing of the path of capitalist agriculture in Russia.... Capitalism ousts the forms of personal dependence that were an inseparable part of the previous economic system. The progressive character of Russian capitalism is especially marked in this respect.... All these changes in the old economic system brought about by capitalism inevitably also bring about a change in the mental outlook of the people. The spasmodic nature of economic development, the abrupt transformation of the methods of production and their intense concentration, the dissolution of all forms of personal dependence and patriarchalism, the mobility of the population, the influence of the big industrial centres, etc. — all this cannot but produce a profound change in the character of the producers, and we have already pointed out the observations of Russian investigators on this score."

The India of the end of the twentieth century was like the Russia of the end of the nineteenth: capitalism developing, while the country still swarmed with feudal survivals. Most of India's population lives in the countryside, and the countryside is the stronghold of feudal forces.

This was in fact one of the key questions pondered by Indian scholars in the twentieth century. Searching for papers, I found this Indian article to be quite comprehensive:

Reflections on Agrarian Change in India since Independence: Does 'Landlordism' Still Matter?

https://summit.sfu.ca/_flysystem/fedora/sfu_migrate/14877/SimonsWorkingPaper14.pdf

The author's view is that, with the development of rural capitalism after the "green revolution" of the 1970s, and the absorption of the rural population by India's industrialisation, "landlordism" — the feudal exploitation of peasants by landlords — has tended to disappear or lose much of its economic significance in most parts of India. Although land reform in the Indian countryside still has some meaning, political mobilisation through the land question has become difficult.

From the 1990s to the 2000s, most young people in China's countryside went out to work wherever they could; many went straight from junior high to factory jobs on the coast, and few young people were willing to farm. Today India is the same: young people do not want to farm. This phenomenon is very common across South Asia. When going out to work earns more than 1,000 yuan a month while farming at home earns no more and you are still exploited by the landlord, who wants to stay in the village? Those who can go abroad go abroad; those who cannot go to the cities to work. Smallholders'

land lies fallow and is gradually absorbed by big farmers, promoting the development of large capitalist agriculture.

Link: <https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/city/hyderabad/youth-abandoning-agriculture-a-crisis-in-telanganas-farming-households/articleshow/114630422.cms>

Source: https://jast.modares.ac.ir/article_16139_25691ceff29458984c3b7e2edb385b54.pdf

Misconception 3 about India: only 100 million people in India are human beings; the other 1.3 billion are subhuman creatures.

This is the greatest misunderstanding about India on the internet.

Refuting it is actually difficult, because everyone on Zhihu has his own standard for what counts as human. I think receiving higher education can count as one standard. One who can receive higher education, and can understand comment-level discussion on Zhihu, can surely count as human.

First, 14.2% of India's working-age population holds a university diploma. Are all university graduates from high castes? Obviously impossible.

The tertiary enrolment rate reflects the same trend. Below is a chart of India's higher education enrolment rate from the World Bank website, consistent with figures published by other institutions — basically credible. Today 34% of India's school-age youth can attend university. If only 10% of Indians were human, how could there be a 34% university enrolment rate? Can subhuman creatures go to university too?

Data source: <https://data.worldbank.org/indicator/SE.TER.ENRR?locations=IN>

Beyond the statistics, the media have also reported. Below is a report about a boy from a Dalit family who got into IIT — India's equivalent of Tsinghua.

Source: <https://www.thehindu.com/news/cities/Delhi/a-dalit-family-prepares-to-send-its-son-to-iit-amid-joy-and-a-hint-of-nervousness/article68706793.ece>

Summary

India's badness comes in two kinds: pre-modern badness and modern badness. Of pre-modern problems, China has few left — apart from customs like bride price, little remains — but Indian society has a whole pile. The modern problems, China and India both have; neither can be called unimportant.

The depiction of India in the Chinese self-media world, just like the BBC's depiction of China, also passes through a filter. As said above, Indian society abounds in the survivals of pre-modern

contradictions, still entangling the younger generation. But as capitalism develops in India, these survivals are bound to be gradually swept away, marginalised, and stripped of their old meaning.

Twenty years from now, the feudal survivals of Indian society will be further reduced, and problems like open defecation will gradually diminish as public facilities improve. But capitalism can only solve the pre-modern "badness"; it cannot solve the "badness" of modern society itself.

The wage problems, overwork, workplace bullying, unemployment, housing prices, and so on mentioned above can only be solved through political and economic movements that go beyond capitalism, and through a new social model. On this point, we may say, when the time comes: "the whole world shares one warmth and one coldness."

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